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UPSC MAINS CORE GROUP 2026



OPTIONAL SUBJECT • INTERVIEW QUESTION BANK

Public Administration

Chapter-wise questions asked in the UPSC Personality Test

22	118	26
real transcripts	questions asked	syllabus chapters

CSE 2019–2025 • Asked + Expected Questions • Answer Angles • Priority Table

"The board tests the lens of your optional, not its syllabus."

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ABOUT THIS COMPILATION

This booklet arranges interview questions asked to Public Administration optional candidates under the 26 chapters of the UPSC syllabus. The **asked** questions come from 22 candidate-shared Personality Test transcripts from CSE 2019 to CSE 2025, mostly published by ForumIAS, Insights IAS and PW OnlyIAS. They are paraphrased, and each carries the CSE year in which it was asked. The **expected** questions are Lukmaan IAS additions for the same chapter, based on the pattern of the asked questions and on current developments.

> **Sources and limits**
>
> Transcripts are candidates' own recollections, so wording is approximate.
>
> Coverage by year: CSE 2019 (2), 2020 (3), 2021 (4), 2022 (7), 2023 (4), 2024 (1), 2025 (1).
>
> Only questions linked to Public Administration are included; general DAF, hobby and current-affairs questions are left out.

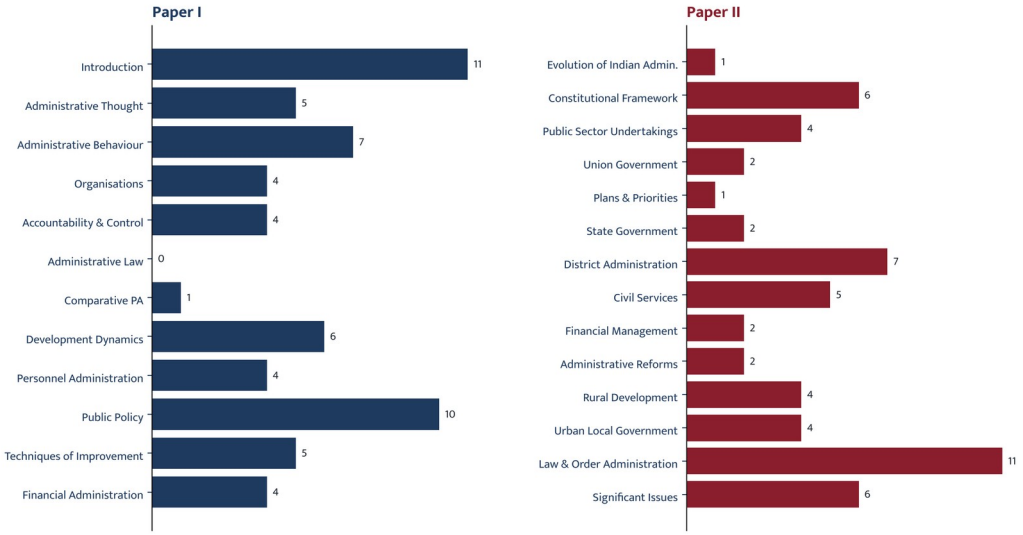


Figure 1. Number of real interview questions found per chapter (22 transcripts, CSE 2019–2025)

What the transcripts show

- **The optional is a small slice.** In most interviews only 2 to 6 of 20 to 30 questions touch Public Administration, usually in one member's short block.
- **Applied chapters dominate.** Law and order, district administration, public policy, civil services and ethics, and leadership are asked far more than thinkers.
- **Weber is the only thinker who recurs.** He came up in three interviews; New Public Administration once. Taylor, Simon, Riggs and Maslow never appeared directly.
- **"As DM, SDM, SP or Secretary" is the main format,** often followed by "the minister insists".
- **Questions start from the DAF.** A job at EPFO led to compliance and GeM; an ICLS officer was asked about NFRA; an engineering degree led to "how does it apply to administration?".
- **Concepts are tied to the news:** freebies through the Sri Lanka crisis, the CIC selection committee through RTI debates, civil servants' hours through the 70-hour-week debate.
- **Expect a counter-question.** "Is Weber relevant?" is followed by "but isn't it too rule-bound?". Take a clear stand, give a reason, then offer a fix.

PAPER I

Administrative Theory

Chapters 1–12

CHAPTER 1

Introduction

Asked in real interviews

1. Why did you choose Public Administration as your optional? **[2019, 2022]**
2. How do your graduation, post-graduation and optional connect, given they are different? **[2023]**
3. Which topic in Public Administration do you like most? **[2022]**
4. What is the difference between administration and management? Are they really different? **[2021]**

5. How do management problems in private firms differ from those in public administration? **[2021]**
6. As a Public Administration student, what would the management side of an IIM syllabus cover? **[2021]**
7. Should government be an actor or an enabler? **[2020]**
8. What does "less government, more governance" mean? **[2020]**
9. Why is New Public Administration not relevant today? What does it lack? **[2023]**
10. What is missing in public administration today, and what should be done? **[2023]**
11. What parallels do you see between public administration and your own discipline? **[2023]**
12. What problems does public administration face in a diverse, complex India? **[2021]**

Expected questions

1. Is Public Administration a science or an art?
2. Has New Public Management made Indian administration more efficient or only more market-minded?
3. What does good governance mean to a citizen standing in a tehsil office?
4. Is New Public Service more suitable for India than New Public Management?
5. Is the politics–administration dichotomy (Wilson) workable in Indian districts?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Lead with a crisp definition or position, then an Indian example. For "why this optional", link it to a real experience from your DAF, not to its scoring potential.

CHAPTER 2

Administrative Thought

Asked in real interviews

1. Define bureaucracy. How does it differ under a monarchy and a democracy? **[2021]**
2. Is Weberian bureaucracy relevant to India? Isn't it too rule-bound? **[2022]**
3. Why was Weber's bureaucratic model adopted in India? What does it offer over other models? **[2022]**
4. Which theory or model of administration best suits India, and why? **[2022]**
5. Have you heard of a particular administrative model? (model named by the member) **[2022]**

Expected questions

1. Is Taylor's scientific management visible in today's government offices?
2. Which motivation theory would you apply to frontline staff such as ASHAs or patwaris?
3. What is Simon's bounded rationality? Give an administrative example.
4. Is Fayol's unity of command compatible with matrix structures and convergence schemes?
5. What did Mary Parker Follett mean by "power with" rather than "power over"?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Boards ask whether a thinker is still relevant. Answer "relevant but incomplete": keep the core (accountability, rules), name the limitation, and add a modern fix.

CHAPTER 3

Administrative Behaviour

Asked in real interviews

1. What is communication? How can communication between officers and junior staff be improved? What are the barriers? **[2022]**
2. Leaders versus managers: are leaders born or made? Give an example from your job. **[2022]**
3. What is the difference between engineers and managers? Should MBA programmes be scrapped? **[2021]**
4. What leadership qualities do posts like RBI Governor need? **[2022]**
5. Should coercion be used in public administration, physical or psychological? **[2023]**
6. What did you learn from leading as a school vice-captain? **[2023]**
7. During riots, would you lead from the front or give orders from the office? **[2019]**

Expected questions

1. How would you motivate a demoralised tehsil office?
2. What is the difference between authority and power?
3. How do you take a decision when information is incomplete?
4. How would you handle a conflict between two senior subordinates?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Use a short story from your own work, school or college, then connect it to a district situation.

CHAPTER 4

Organisations

Asked in real interviews

1. What are EPFO's coverage criteria, and how does it ensure compliance? **[2019]**
2. What does the ICLS do? How do the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, ICAI and NFRA relate? **[2021]**
3. Who regulates print, television and social media? **[2022]**
4. How can the private sector and government combine strengths for development? Is the private sector doing enough? **[2022]**

Expected questions

1. Are independent regulators really independent in India?
2. Should PPPs be used in health and education?
3. Ministry, department, board or corporation: which form suits which task?
4. Are statutory bodies more accountable than executive bodies?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Know the organisations in your own DAF in detail: who regulates whom, under which law, and one current issue.

CHAPTER 5

Accountability and Control

Asked in real interviews

1. What are the “5 C” problems of the civil services? Do the CAG, CBI, CIC, CVC and courts hamper civil servants? **[2022]**
2. Who sits on the committee that appoints the Chief Information Commissioner? **[2025]**
3. What about citizens' grievances? Is there technology that lets citizens be heard? **[2023]**
4. Why are human-rights NGOs in trouble? Is the government overreacting? **[2022]**

Expected questions

1. Does RTI help or hamper administration?
2. Why have citizen charters not worked well in India?
3. How effective is social audit under MGNREGA?
4. How does Parliament control the executive in practice?
5. Is the Lokpal effective?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Balance accountability with the freedom to take decisions. Mention safeguards such as protection for bona fide decisions.

CHAPTER 6

Administrative Law

> **Asked in real interviews**
>
> No direct question found in the 22 transcripts studied. Prepare the expected questions below; boards can still ask them.

Expected questions

1. What are the principles of natural justice? Give an administrative example.
2. Why is delegated legislation needed, and how is it controlled?
3. Have tribunals reduced the burden on courts or created a parallel system?
4. What is the difference between a quasi-judicial and an administrative function of a DM?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Link each concept to a district situation, such as hearing both sides before cancelling a licence.

CHAPTER 7

Comparative Public Administration

Asked in real interviews

1. Which model of administration best suits the Indian setting, and why? **[2022]**

Expected questions

1. What is Riggs' prismatic society? Is it visible in your district?
2. What is formalism? Give an example.
3. What can Indian administration learn from another country's civil service?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Use the ecology idea: administration reflects its social setting. Give one concrete example of a gap between rules and practice.

CHAPTER 8

Development Dynamics

Asked in real interviews

1. Why does Uttar Pradesh lag behind the southern states? What would you do? **[2022]**
2. Why is Bihar failing to use its demographic dividend? **[2021]**
3. What do you think of the Narmada Andolan? **[2022]**
4. How do you balance development and environment, for example at hill stations? **[2024]**
5. How do you balance big infrastructure projects in a fragile state? **[2025]**
6. What is the “Pradhan Pati” phenomenon in panchayats, and how would you end it? **[2022]**

Expected questions

1. Is development administration still relevant?
2. What is anti-development thinking? Do you agree with it?
3. Has women's reservation in panchayats empowered women?
4. What role should NGOs play in development?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Show both sides of development, then state what a district officer can do: consultation, resettlement and benefit-sharing.

CHAPTER 9

Personnel Administration

Asked in real interviews

1. Can a science graduate apply science in administration? **[2020]**
2. How does civil engineering knowledge apply to administration? **[2021]**
3. Senior officials are appointed at the government's discretion. Has that produced good leaders? **[2022]**
4. You oppose a 70-hour work week, yet civil servants work more. How do you reconcile this? **[2023]**

Expected questions

1. Generalist or specialist: who should run ministries?
2. Is the APAR system fair? What did the Dev Dutt case say?

3. Lateral entry: good idea or not?
4. Can Mission Karmayogi change behaviour, not just skills?
5. Should civil servants have a fixed tenure?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Use your own degree as evidence of what specialists bring, but defend the generalist's coordinating role.

CHAPTER 10

Public Policy

Asked in real interviews

1. Which public policies would you bring in? **[2022]**
2. Does one-size-fits-all food fortification hurt public health? What is the alternative? **[2022]**
3. Is the vehicle scrapping policy right? What would you change? **[2021]**
4. Is spending on health and education also a freebie? Should India adopt a universal basic income? **[2021]**
5. How can the government deliver its promises to startups? **[2022]**
6. How can the healthcare system be made resilient? Preventive versus promotive care. **[2021]**
7. How can begging on Indian streets be reduced? **[2023]**
8. Should drug users be treated as victims or offenders? **[2022]**
9. What reforms would you make to your state's tourism policy? **[2025]**
10. What goes wrong in land acquisition, and how can compensation complaints be reduced? **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. Why do good policies fail at implementation?
2. How should a policy be evaluated? Give an example.
3. Should policy be made on evidence or on public demand?
4. Top-down or bottom-up implementation: which works in India?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Answer as a policy cycle: problem, options, choice, implementation, evaluation. Always add who is most affected.

CHAPTER 11

Techniques of Administrative Improvement

Asked in real interviews

1. How can smartphones be used in administration? **[2021]**
2. Would administrators have an easier job without smartphones and social media? **[2023]**
3. How has India done in digital governance? **[2023]**
4. How is transparency ensured in procurement through GeM? **[2019]**

5. As SP, what technology would you use? **[2021]**

Expected questions

1. Is e-governance the same as good governance?
2. How would you use data or GIS in district planning?
3. What is the digital divide, and how do you avoid excluding people?
4. How would you reduce file pendency in your office?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Praise the gains of technology, then name the excluded citizen and the human fallback you would keep.

CHAPTER 12

Financial Administration

Asked in real interviews

1. What is the difference between output and outcome in outcome budgeting? **[2020]**
2. What is the difference between plan and non-plan expenditure? **[2025]**
3. Would you buy office furniture through GeM or a private vendor? **[2019]**
4. What is the MSME procurement policy? **[2022]**

Expected questions

1. What is zero-based budgeting, and can it work in India?
2. What is the role of the CAG and the Public Accounts Committee?
3. What is gender budgeting?
4. Why do departments rush to spend in March?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Define precisely, then give a district example of how the concept changes spending decisions.

PAPER II

Indian Administration

Chapters 13–26

CHAPTER 13

Evolution of Indian Administration

Asked in real interviews

1. What lessons from Shivaji Maharaj are useful for governance today? **[2020]**

Expected questions

1. What does Kautilya's Arthashastra teach a modern administrator?
2. Which features of British administration still shape the district?

3. Was the Collector created for revenue or for welfare?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Draw one lesson from history and apply it to a present-day district problem.

CHAPTER 14

Philosophical and Constitutional Framework

Asked in real interviews

1. What are the ways of amending the Constitution? **[2020]**
2. What was the 1st Constitutional Amendment? Should the basic structure be defined? **[2023]**
3. What is wrong with the election process, and what reforms are needed? **[2020]**
4. What is the role of dissent in democracy? Name dissents later accepted by the Supreme Court. **[2025]**
5. Why was Article 370 abrogated, and what has been its impact? **[2025]**
6. Why are states building their own digital libraries when a national one exists? **[2023]**

Expected questions

1. Is Indian federalism under strain?
2. How should Directive Principles guide a DM?
3. Is the Constitution a social contract?
4. What does constitutional morality mean for a civil servant?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Stay constitutional and neutral. Cite the Article or case, then explain what it means for administration.

CHAPTER 15

Public Sector Undertakings

Asked in real interviews

1. Should PSUs diversify, for example into EV charging? Do they compete on unequal terms? **[2023]**
2. Has the government's attitude to profit changed since the Nehru era? **[2022]**
3. Why are bad loans higher in public sector banks? Should banks be privatised? **[2020]**
4. Why is the government merging banks? **[2019]**

Expected questions

1. Should strategic PSUs be privatised?
2. How should PSUs balance social obligations and profit?
3. Do PSUs have real autonomy?

Answer angle

Separate strategic and non-strategic sectors, and show the social role a PSU plays in your answer.

CHAPTER 16

Union Government and Administration

Asked in real interviews

1. What is the highest post a civil servant can reach? **[2020]**
2. As a Secretary to the Government of India, how would you handle sewage treatment plants? **[2020]**

Expected questions

1. What does the Cabinet Secretary do?
2. Has the PMO become too powerful?
3. How does a ministry coordinate with the states?

Answer angle

Know the structure, then explain how coordination actually works between ministries and states.

CHAPTER 17

Plans and Priorities

Asked in real interviews

1. Are Five-Year Plans still used? What replaced them? Give an example. **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. How is NITI Aayog different from the Planning Commission?
2. What is the Aspirational Districts Programme, and why does it work?
3. Has cooperative federalism improved planning?

Answer angle

Compare old and new planning in one line each, then give one district-level example.

CHAPTER 18

State Government and Administration

Asked in real interviews

1. What is your view of Bihar? How would you improve the state's image? **[2023]**
2. Why does Uttar Pradesh lag behind the southern states? **[2022]**

Expected questions

1. What is the role of the Chief Secretary?
2. Should Governors have a time limit to act on bills?
3. How do centre–state relations affect your state's development?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Use your home state's data and one positive initiative before naming its problems.

CHAPTER 19

District Administration

Asked in real interviews

1. As DM, a report shows low nutrition among girls. What steps would you take? **[2022]**
2. As DM, a child falls into a borewell. What would you do? **[2022]**
3. What would be your first step as an SDM? **[2021]**
4. If you were in charge of your district, what would you focus on? **[2022]**
5. How would you contribute at taluka or district level? **[2020]**
6. As DM with limited funds, would you upgrade the hospital or build a new one? The minister insists on a new one. **[2025]**
7. How would you stop the yearly river erosion in your district? **[2022]**

Expected questions

1. Is the Collector overburdened? What can be delegated?
2. How would you coordinate line departments for a convergence scheme?
3. What would your first 30 days as DM look like?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Give immediate steps, a systemic fix and a review mechanism. Name the departments you would involve.

CHAPTER 20

Civil Services

Asked in real interviews

1. What qualities does a civil servant need, and where have you shown them? **[2021]**
2. How can professionalism in administration be increased? **[2022]**
3. Why was the Ethics paper introduced in 2013? Can ethics be tested in writing? **[2022]**
4. Why do ethics and attitude matter for civil servants? **[2022]**
5. A minister wants a highway against the EIA findings. What do you do? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. Neutrality or commitment: which should a civil servant have?
2. Should civil servants be active on social media?
3. Is the All India Services model still relevant?

4. What reforms does the civil service need most?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Combine values and procedure: respect the elected executive, record your advice, and follow the law.

CHAPTER 21

Financial Management

Asked in real interviews

1. What is the difference between plan and non-plan expenditure? **[2025]**
2. Is spending on health and education a freebie? **[2021]**

Expected questions

1. How has GST changed centre–state finances?
2. What is the role of the Finance Commission?
3. How should states manage rising debt?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Link fiscal concepts to service delivery: what the money buys for a citizen.

CHAPTER 22

Administrative Reforms since Independence

Asked in real interviews

1. How has India done in digital governance? **[2023]**
2. What is missing in public administration, and what should be done? **[2023]**

Expected questions

1. Which 2nd ARC recommendation would you implement first?
2. Why do reforms stay on paper?
3. Has Mission Karmayogi changed training?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Pick one reform, give its intent, one result and one gap, then propose a practical next step.

CHAPTER 23

Rural Development

Asked in real interviews

1. What do you think of Panchayati Raj? How does your village panchayat perform? **[2022]**
2. What is the “Pradhan Pati” or “Sarpanch Pati” phenomenon, and how would you end it? **[2022]**

3. What problems does MGNREGA face in your state? **[2021]**
4. What credit problems do farmers face? **[2022]**

Expected questions

1. Why is devolution of funds, functions and functionaries incomplete?
2. How can gram sabhas be made effective?
3. Are rural development schemes reaching the poorest?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Use your own village or block as evidence, then suggest one capacity-building step.

CHAPTER 24

Urban Local Government

Asked in real interviews

1. What is the difference between urbanisation and urban development? Do cities lack a master plan? **[2024]**
2. When was the first National Commission on Urbanisation set up? **[2024]**
3. As a civil engineer, how would you solve Bengaluru's problems? **[2023]**
4. How should overcrowding at hill stations be handled? **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. Why have urban local bodies remained weak after the 74th Amendment?
2. Has the Smart Cities Mission succeeded?
3. Should cities have directly elected mayors with real powers?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Name the urban problem, the responsible body and its funding gap, then propose one planning or finance fix.

CHAPTER 25

Law and Order Administration

Asked in real interviews

1. How does the public see the police? Which community policing models are best? **[2021]**
2. What is the difference between law and order and public order? **[2021]**
3. Why are law-and-order incidents rising despite heavy police spending? **[2024]**
4. What are the functions of the police? Is security a shared public good? **[2023]**
5. As Delhi Police Commissioner during riots, what would you have done? **[2019]**
6. Why should the government provide security at all? Is it a case of “might is right”? **[2019]**
7. Should Left Wing Extremism be treated as terrorism? **[2022]**
8. The government signs peace deals with extremist groups. Doesn't that reward the wrong behaviour? **[2023]**
9. How do you balance individual rights against national security under AFSPA? **[2020]**

10. What was the protest against the hit-and-run law about? **[2023]**
11. Do you agree with using a stone-pelter as a human shield? **[2022]**

Expected questions

1. Why have Prakash Singh police reforms been slow?
2. How would you build trust between police and a community?
3. How should police use technology without violating privacy?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Uphold the rule of law and human rights together. Give immediate action, then a trust-building step.

CHAPTER 26

Significant Issues in Indian Administration

Asked in real interviews

1. Can a written paper test ethics? Does it bring ethics into the system? **[2022]**
2. What is rent-seeking in politics and business? **[2021]**
3. How is India doing in disaster management? What are the lessons? **[2020]**
4. Should coercion be used in public administration? **[2023]**
5. A minister overrides an environmental impact assessment. What do you do? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. How would you reduce corruption in your own office?
2. What is the citizen–administration interface, and how can it improve?
3. How should a DM prepare for a disaster before it happens?
4. What does integrity mean beyond not taking bribes?

> **Answer angle**
>
> Combine a value with a system: personal integrity plus transparency, timelines and records.

Priority for the final weeks

Priority	Chapters	Why
High	Law and Order (25), Introduction (1), Public Policy (10), District Administration (19), Administrative Behaviour (3)	Most questions in real boards; usually scenario or opinion based
Medium	Constitutional Framework (14), Development Dynamics (8), Significant Issues (26), Civil Services (20), Administrative Thought (2), Techniques of Improvement (11)	Asked regularly, often linked to current events or your DAF
Lower	Organisations (4), Accountability (5), Personnel (9), Financial Administration (12), PSUs (15), Rural (23) and Urban (24) Local Government	Asked when your DAF, job or home state points there

Priority	Chapters	Why
Prepare briefly	Administrative Law (6), Comparative PA (7), Evolution (13), Union Government (16), Plans (17), State Government (18), Financial Management (21), Reforms (22)	Rarely asked; know the basics and one current example

How to use these questions

Prepare **all 26 chapters at answer-angle depth**, not textbook depth. Boards test application.

Give the **four-beat answer**: position, reason, other side, what you would do as an officer.

Link at least one chapter to **each line of your DAF**, such as your degree, job or home district.

Revise the **current linkages** for your chapters: RTI and the CIC, police reform, urban planning, PSU policy.

Sources: candidate-shared CSE 2019–2025 interview transcripts published by ForumIAS, Insights IAS and PW OnlyIAS; questions paraphrased.

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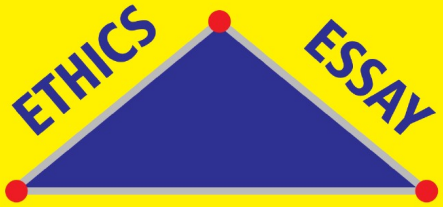
291 Marks	302 Marks	334 Marks
		
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AIR 370 CSE 2025
Essay Test Series 2024

119 Marks in Essay



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AIR 03 CSE 2025
Essay Mock Test 2023

Public Admin. (Optional) Highest Marks

291 Marks in PA



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289 Marks in PA



SATVIK SHARMA
AIR 327 CSE 2025
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PA Test Series 2025

These candidates from Lukmaan IAS achieved remarkable ranks in UPSC CSE 2025, highlighting the institute's strong support in Ethics, Essay, test series, and optional subjects like Public Administration.

Yashaswi Raj Vardhan (AIR 11): Secured highest rank for **Public Administration optional (291 marks, top score).** Enrolled in Public Admin Foundation 2023, Crash Course 2025, and Ethics Crash Course 2025. Achieved in second attempt through discipline and consistency.

Akansh Dhull (AIR 3): Scored 1057 total marks in fourth attempt. Courses: Ethics Test Series 2023, Case Studies 2023, Essay Mock Test 2023, IGP. Standout scores: **Ethics 134, Essay 119, Interview 193.** B.Com from SRCC (DU); from Chandigarh/Haryana; optional Commerce & Accountancy.

Rajeshwari Suve M (AIR 2): Enrolled in Ethics Test Series 2023 & 2025. From Vadipatti, Madurai (TN); B.E. Electrical & Electronics from Anna University; optional Sociology. Serving as Deputy Collector (Training) in TN govt post-TNPSC Group 1.

Ishan Bhatnagar (AIR 5): From Lucknow (UP), resides in Bhopal (MP); born 2001. Courses: GS Mains Test Series 2023, Essay & Ethics Test Series 2025. Son of Amitabh Bhatnagar (Good Governance Institute) and Prof. Vinita Bhatnagar.

This group showcases Lukmaan IAS's impact on high scorers, especially in Ethics (multiple 130+ scores) and structured test prep.

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Ethics & Essay Test Series 2023
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CSE 2024



Mayank Triphathi
CSE 2024



Ashish Kumar
CSE 2023



Nausheen
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